

Ebooks: For or against?

Topic: Electronic books

Aims:

- To help students argue for and against ebooks and other topics
- To develop students' writing skills
- To develop students' reading skills
- To develop students' speaking and listening skills

Level: Intermediate B1

Introduction

Are you for or against electronic books? In this lesson, students read about the advantages and disadvantages of electronic books. They look at language for essay writing and the informal language of blog comments. Students have 'for or against' discussions on various topics. They write a 'for or against' blog entry and respond to their classmates' writing with written comments.

Procedure

Lead in

- Tell the class about a friend who has an electronic book. Ask if the students know anyone who has an ebook. What can they tell you about ebooks?
- Draw the following chart on the board. As a class, list ideas for and against electronic books, e.g., ebooks are cheap, paper books are easier to read. Leave the notes on the board.

Electronic books

<i>Advantages</i>	<i>Disadvantages</i>

Task 1: Read

- Hand out **Task 1**. Ask students to look at the text. Can they identify the blog entry (the first part) and the comments section (the second part)? Ask students to read the blog entry (they will read the comments section later) quickly and decide if the writer is for or against ebooks (the writer is neutral; neither for nor against). Set a two-minute time limit.
- Ask students to do exercise A. They could say if the writer agrees with the class's list of advantages and disadvantages on the board.
- Ask the students to do exercise B individually and then compare answers in pairs.
- Students read the comments section and do exercise C and D in pairs.
- Ask the students if they agree with any of the comments.

Task 1: Read
Blog on. The 'for or against' blog.
Electronic books or paper books?

Are electronic books better than traditional paper books? Ebooks are very popular these days but many readers prefer paper books.

Some people think that electronic books are great. You can store thousands of books on an ebook, whereas paper books take up lots of space at home. You don't need to go to a bookshop because you can buy and receive books online instantly.

On the other hand, printed books are still very popular. Some people prefer to hold a 'real' book and like to touch paper pages. You can lend a favourite book to a friend but you can't borrow your friend's ereader for a couple of weeks. Also, electronic books are very expensive.

To sum up, I think that electronic books are a really useful invention. Many people use them but they won't replace paper books in the future. What do you think?

Blog comments: Tell us what you think?

Ebooks are *rubbish!* They are really expensive and you can't read them in the bath.
Graham, UK

I use my ereader when I go on holiday. I can take lots of books and there's still a lot of room left in my suitcase for clothes and other stuff. *Great!*
Sarah, Hong Kong

Ebooks are the future. In twenty years we won't be reading paper books.
Jaime, Canada

Paper books are destroying trees!
Scott, Germany

Ebooks are just for rich people who need to have the latest gadget to show to their friends. *I'm sticking with* paperbacks.
Jules, USA

I love my ebook. It's very light, you can change the size of the words, you can make notes on the pages, you can buy a book with a couple of clicks AND you can download books for free. *What's not to like?*
Tamsin, Netherlands.

I work in a bookshop. What happens to people like me if everyone stops buying books?
Jon, New Zealand

A) Read the blog entry 'Electronic books or paper books?'. What are the advantages and disadvantages of ebooks according to the writer?

B) Read the blog entry again and match the underlined parts of the text with these words and expressions:

1 As well as this also

- 2 but _____
 3 However _____
 4 In conclusion _____
 5 nowadays _____
 6 On the one hand _____

C) Read the comments section. Which person...

- 1 ...likes ebooks because they are small? Sarah
 2 ...is worried about the environment? _____
 3 ...thinks ebooks are only for people with a lot of money? _____
 4 ...doesn't pay to download ebooks? _____
 5 ...doesn't like ebooks because they cost a lot of money? _____
 6 ...thinks nobody will read traditional books in the future? _____
 7 ...is worried about his job? _____

D) Match the descriptions with the words in *italics* in 'Blog comments'.

- 1 Very good _____
 2 Bad _____
 3 There is nothing negative _____
 4 I'm going to continue using _____

Answers Task 1:

B: 1 also, 2 whereas, 3 On the other hand, 4 To sum up, 5 these days, 6 some people think that

C: 1 Sarah, 2 Scott, 3 Jules, 4 Tamsin, 5 Graham, 6 Jaime, 7 Jon

D: 1 Great, 2 rubbish, 3 What's not to like?, 4 I'm sticking with

Task 2: Discuss

- Hand out **Task 2**. Tell the students that they are going to discuss the topics in Task 2 but first they need to prepare what they want to say. Give students a time limit of 5 minutes to read the discussion topics and make notes 'for' and 'against'. Students discuss the topics in small groups.
- Each group could choose a spokesperson to report back group opinions to the class.

Task 2: Discuss

Are you for or against? Discuss these topics in groups.

- 1 Emails or letters?
 2 Text message or phone call?
 3 Plane or boat?
 4 Electric toothbrush or traditional toothbrush?
 5 Credit card or cash?
 6 Computer game or board game?
 7 Car or bike?

Task 3: Write

- Hand out **Task 3** and tell the students to look at exercise A. In pairs or threes, students write a 'for or against' blog entry. The pairs or groups can choose one of the discussion topics from Task 2 or they can invent a different title.

- Students should use the blog entry in Task 1 as a model for their writing and write 4 paragraphs, an introduction, a paragraph with reasons 'for', a paragraph with reasons 'against' and a conclusion. Encourage students to use the words and expressions from Task 1B.
- With a weaker class you could write a blog entry on the board as a class. Ask students to tell you what to write and feed in ideas and language as necessary. Students then use the model on the board to write on a different topic in pairs or threes.

Tip: Fast finishers could add more discussion topics to the list in Task 2 and then talk about them.

- To do exercise B students swap papers with a different group. They could all pass their papers to the group on the left or you could collect them in and hand them out to different groups. Students read their classmates' blog and then add their opinion in the comments section. Walk around the class and give lots of help. Encourage students to use the informal language from Task 1D. Set a time limit of five minutes so that the groups finish at the same time.
- Students swap papers with a different group, read and add another comment. Swap papers and repeat. Continue over the page if necessary.
- Display the 'blogs' on the wall for all to read.

Task 3: Write

A) Write a 'for or against' blog entry. Use words and expressions from Task 1B.

Blog on. The 'for or against' blog.

_____ or _____?

B) Change papers and comment on your classmates' blogs. Use some of the words and expressions from Task 1D.

Blog comments: Tell us what you think?